

River Ridge High School



Royal Sound Band Program Membership Handbook (2025-2026)

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Preface

This handbook has been prepared to provide students and parents with important information about the various aspects, activities, and policies of the River Ridge High School Band Program. While it may not answer every question, it will provide a clear overview of what to expect throughout the year.

All students and parents should read this handbook carefully, complete the handbook contract form located in the back, sign it, and return it to the band office. This ensures that everyone understands the expectations and procedures of the program. School rules and policies are always in effect whenever a student is participating—either directly or indirectly—in any activity associated with River Ridge High School.

The band director reserves the right to adjust, add, or suspend policies at any time if it is determined to be in the best interest of the program and its students.

Welcome

The high school band experience is unique, and incoming students will find it both challenging and rewarding. Marching Band, Jazz Band, Concert Band, Eurhythmics (Colorguard), Indoor Percussion and Colorguard offer students many opportunities to explore and enrich their personal and musical development. Students will have the chance to perform in the community, travel, and take part in experiences they will remember for the rest of their lives.

In addition to the many educational and cultural benefits, students grow socially and emotionally through music. For students entering a large school and facing new situations, band provides a place to belong and a community where they are supported and valued.

The band program also offers opportunities to develop leadership skills. Communication, teamwork, goal setting, time management, and other important life skills are emphasized, helping students build self-confidence. Band members at River Ridge consistently excel academically, with many being honor students and leaders in other areas of the school.

Our program strives for excellence in all areas. River Ridge ensembles consistently earn Superior ratings at Florida Bandmasters Association (FBA) District Music Performance Assessments for Marching Band, Jazz Band, and Concert Band. The Royal Sound Marching Band has earned top placements at FMBC and FFCC regional events, and our Indoor Percussion and Color Guard programs have achieved state and regional championships, including both teams earning first place at FFCC Championships in 2025. Band members are often involved in other sports, clubs,

and school activities, and with planning and communication, flexible scheduling can be arranged to support participation in multiple programs.

The River Ridge High School Band will provide you with a fulfilling and enriching musical and educational experience. Our goal is to create a positive environment where every student has the opportunity to succeed. Together, we will make this a year to remember.

Sincerely,

Carly Scholz, Band and Orchestra Director

cscholz@pasco.k12.fl.us

Band Organizations and Course Offerings

Symphonic Band

The River Ridge High School Symphonic Band is the school's premier concert ensemble, featuring talented student musicians who perform repertoire with precision and expression. Through dedicated rehearsals and public performances, the band showcases musical excellence and represents the high standards of the River Ridge music program.

Knights of Jazz

The Knights of Jazz is River Ridge High School's premier jazz ensemble, this auditioned group is made up of skilled and passionate student musicians. The band explores a variety of jazz genres including swing, bebop, Latin, blues, and funk, offering dynamic performances that highlight both individual improvisation and tight ensemble playing. The Knights of Jazz perform regularly at school concerts, local events, and jazz festivals, proudly representing the creativity and excellence of the River Ridge music program.

Orchestra

The River Ridge High School Orchestra Program is a new growing and vibrant part of the school's music department. The program emphasizes musical growth, ensemble collaboration, and performance excellence through the study of various repertoire. As the program continues to grow, it provides students with meaningful performance experiences at school concerts, community events, and district assessments, fostering a lifelong appreciation for music and the arts.

Royal Sound Marching Band

The Royal Sound Marching Band is the spirited and high-energy marching ensemble of River Ridge High School. Known for its powerful performances, precision drill, and school pride, the band plays a central role in energizing the crowd football games, parades, and competitions throughout the season. Combining musicianship, athleticism, and teamwork, the Royal Sound

provides students with unforgettable performance experiences while proudly representing the tradition and excellence of the River Ridge music program.

Indoor Percussion

The River Ridge Indoor Percussion ensemble is a dynamic and award-winning performance group that blends music, movement, and visual design. In 2025, the group earned 1st place at the WGI Orlando Regional and took home 1st place at the FFCC Championships, showcasing their talent, creativity, and dedication. As one of the school's most elite ensembles, they continue to set a high standard for excellence and innovation in the marching arts.

Colorguard

The River Ridge High School Colorguard is a talented and expressive ensemble that brings music to life through movement, choreography, and equipment work. With powerful performances both on the field and in the gym, the team showcases grace, strength, and creativity. In 2025, they earned 1st place at the FFCC Championships, celebrating a season of excellence and hard work. The Color Guard continues to be a proud and dynamic part of the River Ridge performing arts program.

The Royal Standard

Attendance

The minimum expectation for attendance is 100%. Every rehearsal and performance is important to the success of the ensemble, and all members are expected to be present and prepared.

- **Early = On Time** – Arriving early ensures you have time to set up and be ready to begin at the scheduled start.
- **On Time = Late** – Arriving at the exact start time means you are already behind.
- **Be Prepared** – Always have all required materials (instrument, music, pencil, equipment, etc.) ready before rehearsal begins.

Consistent attendance and preparation are essential for both individual and group success.

Respect

Every member of the River Ridge High School Band is expected to show respect in all situations. How we treat others and represent our program reflects on the entire ensemble.

- **Respect People** – Show courtesy to fellow students, parents, staff, and community members.
- **Respect Boundaries** – Be mindful of personal space and the comfort of others.
- **Respect Equipment** – Take care of all instruments, uniforms, music, and facilities.
- **Use Appropriate Language** – Speak in a way that reflects maturity and professionalism.

- **Represent the Band at All Times** – Your actions both in and out of rehearsal should reflect positively on our program.
- **Be Aware of Time and Place** – Conduct yourself appropriately for the setting you are in.

Respect is a cornerstone of our band culture, and it is essential for a positive, productive, and safe environment.

Rehearsal Etiquette

Our rehearsals are most productive when everyone is focused, prepared, and engaged. Each member contributes to the overall success of the group.

- **Enthusiastic Participation** – Give your best effort in every activity, exercise, and performance run.
- **Silence Between Reps** – Remain quiet between repetitions so instructions can be given quickly and clearly.
- **Show Up Early and Prepared** – Arrive with enough time to set up, warm up, and have all materials ready before rehearsal begins.
- **Ask Questions** – If you are unsure about something, ask for clarification at the appropriate time.

Consistent rehearsal etiquette ensures we make the most of our time together and achieve our highest level of performance.

Performance Etiquette

When performing or attending an event as a member of the River Ridge High School Band, you are representing our school, our program, and our community. Your actions should reflect pride, professionalism, and respect at all times.

- **Representative Behavior** – Conduct yourself in a way that reflects positively on our program both on and off the performance area.
- **Good Sportsmanship** – Support and encourage other performers, regardless of the outcome of a competition or event.
- **Show Respect** – Treat the host school, other bands, directors, parents, and all individuals you encounter with courtesy.
- **Be Aware of Time and Place** – Understand the setting you are in and act appropriately for the occasion.

Our reputation is built on the way we carry ourselves both musically and personally. Every performance is an opportunity to strengthen that reputation.

Mindset

Success in music comes from persistence, adaptability, and a positive attitude. The way you approach challenges directly impacts your growth as a musician and as a member of the ensemble.

- **Adopt a Growth Mindset** – Believe that your skills can improve with effort and practice.
- **Use “Yet”** – Replace “I can’t play this” with “I can’t play this yet.”
- **View Challenges as Opportunities** – See difficult music or techniques as chances to grow.
- **Embrace Constructive Feedback** – Accept feedback openly and use it to make meaningful improvements.

A strong mindset helps create a culture of learning, resilience, and excellence within our band.

Following The Royal Standard means committing to the values and expectations that define the River Ridge High School Band. By showing respect, maintaining excellent attendance, demonstrating proper rehearsal and performance etiquette, and adopting a growth mindset, every member helps create a positive and high-achieving culture.

Attendance Policy

Every day a student attends a class or music rehearsal is an opportunity to increase a student’s musical ability. Half the battle is just showing up and being on time! For the organization to run effectively, we must have every student at every rehearsal and performance. Excessive absences not only inhibit learning, but they also hold back the entire organization, not just the absent student. Every member of the band is a critical part of the performance.

A student's grade will be a direct reflection of their ability to meet the classroom expectations for improvement, preparation, attendance, and performance. As a Co-curricular Class a large percentage of the students’ grade will be reflective of their ability to meet the responsibility and obligations of rehearsals and performances occurring outside of the actual school day class.

The minimum expectation for attendance in the River Ridge High School Band is 100%. We understand that life can be unpredictable, and we are willing to be flexible when necessary. However, we ask that you exhaust all options before scheduling appointments, trips, or other commitments during scheduled band events.

Absences will be handled on a case-by-case basis and must be communicated directly by a parent or guardian to Ms. Scholz. Please note that work, birthday parties, lack of transportation, and being behind on homework are never acceptable reasons to miss band events. Band staff reserves the right to pull a student from a performance at any time due to rehearsal absences.

Please help us maintain the Royal Standard and support our program by prioritizing attendance at all rehearsals and performances.

Dress Code

Rehearsal Uniform (Marching Band)

- Purple Royal Sound Shirt
- Athletic bottoms
- Athletic shoes (make sure these are comfortable and you can move in them!)
- Socks
- Sunscreen
- Hat, sunglasses (optional, highly recommended)

Under Uniform (Marching Band)

- Purple Royal Sound shirt OR current year show shirt (see itinerary)
- Black shorts/ leggings
- Long black socks, no logos or emblems
- Bandos (marching shoes)
- Subtle jewelry may be worn (jewelry is handled at the discretion of the director)
- Hair must be up so it can go in your shako

Concert Uniform (Symphonic Band, Percussion, Jazz Band, etc)

- All black top, bottoms, or dress. No emblems, logos, distracting embellishments, etc)
- Students must have AT LEAST mid upper arm length sleeves. Long sleeves are preferred. No visible shoulders.
- Black dressy shoes. Must be ALL BLACK, no white soles or emblems. Subtle accents (ex. Silver buckles) are okay. No sneakers. Close toed shoes are preferred.

Football Game Procedures

- Please arrive early enough that you are set and ready when the clock hits call time. If you are not set and ready in your spot you will be marked late.
- Student leadership will perform inspections on the band. Inspection requirements will be included in the weekly itinerary. Any student who does not pass inspection will result in their entire section losing the privilege to leave the stands during the third-quarter break.

Uniform Guidelines:

- For away games, students are required to wear their uniforms for the entire trip unless otherwise directed by the band director.
- Students will proceed to their assigned buses and complete bus inspection with staff/ leadership.
- Upon arrival at the stadium, students will go directly to the band section in the stands and sit in their assigned seats.
- The band seating area is restricted to band members, chaperones, and staff only. Friends and family are not permitted to sit in the band section of the stands.
- Chaperones have the full authority of the band director and volunteer their time to support the band's success.
- After the halftime show, students will return to the stands. The band will be dismissed together for the third quarter break.
- After the game, students will line up to march back to the band room or buses.
- Students are not permitted to leave or remove their uniforms until dismissed by the band director.
- All student leadership members are required to remain in the band room until dismissed by the band director.
- Students will remove their uniforms, clean up personal belongings, and exit the band room in an orderly manner.

Important Reminders:

- Please pick up your student promptly. Parents who are more than 45 minutes late may have their child escorted home by the sheriff's department. Band staff and volunteers are not responsible for late pickups. Please plan transportation accordingly.
- **Cell phone use is not permitted during football games.** Phones used in the stands will be confiscated and held by a chaperone until the end of the game.
- Students represent River Ridge High School and are expected to maintain appropriate behavior and attitude throughout the event.

Academic Standards

Performing in marching band is a privilege, and such a privilege may be lost due to poor grades, attendance problems, or other circumstances. All students will be required to maintain an active 2.0 GPA in all classes. Students that fail to do so will not be allowed to march at football games until they prove they have raised their grades. Students' band grades will not be affected because

of this rule. Students will be required to check in with Ms. Scholz at the end of each progress report period (8 total) to review academic progress.

General Bus Travel Procedures

All students must ride their designated bus. Bus assignments will only be changed at the discretion of the band director. Assigned seats on busses may be given at any time. Chaperones will be assigned to each bus. Chaperones have the band director's full authority. Any discipline problems will be reported, and no lenience will be provided to infractions associated with chaperones. There will be no exceptions to this rule.

Public Displays of Affection (PDA) are **strictly prohibited**. The first occurrence will result in a warning. The second and any subsequent occurrences will result in disciplinary action including alternate seating assignments, parent conferences, and/or suspension from the program.

Cell phones are allowed at your own risk. Cell phones can be used for texting, gaming, or music listening purposes (with headphones only). The band program is not responsible for any damage that may occur to personal devices.

Parent Support and Boosters

The River Ridge High School Band Boosters 501(c)(3) are essential to the success of our program. Booster parents support the band through fundraising, event planning, transportation coordination, uniform care, and many other vital activities. This program would not run nearly as smoothly without the support of boosters. Their dedication helps provide the resources and opportunities that allow our students to thrive both musically and personally.

River Ridge High School Band Booster Executive Board and Committee Chairs

President- Shannon Forcade

Vice President- Tracey Krinn

Secretary- Jillian Lay

Treasurer- Shawna Speer

Co-Treasurer- Samantha Stevenson

Volunteer Coordinator- Brianne Kramer

Equipment and Logistics Coordinators- Clay Krinn, Todd Pigeon, Eric Forcade

Sponsorship Coordinators- Sue Lyons, Cynthia Cook

Because boosters work closely with students and support all band activities, all volunteers must complete the Pasco County Schools fingerprinting and volunteer clearance process. This ensures a safe and secure environment for our students. We appreciate the commitment of all booster members in fulfilling these requirements and supporting our band family.

Please see the list at the end of the handbook acknowledgement form and let us know which ways you would like to support our band program or reach out to any of our booster board members to get connected! **We need your help!**

Communication

Communication for band will be through our Royal Sound Members and Parents Only Facebook page and through MyStudent. Please keep an eye and check both of these regularly to ensure that you do not miss out on vital information.

Band Fees and Payment Options

Like any strong organization, a little bit of ‘money power’ is required for smooth running. Believe it or not, our entire program operates on a 30-40k budget each year! Each marching band student is responsible for paying their band fees of \$300. If a student needs shoes they will pay an additional \$30, and if a student needs new rehearsal shirts they are \$15 each. First year members will be given two practice shirts as a part of their \$300 fees. Your band fee payment goes towards paying instructional staff, dry cleaning, band shirts, competition registration fees, equipment, music, uniforms and more.

Fees for Indoor Percussion and Colorguard are separate from Marching Band Fees.

Band fees can be paid with cash or check made out to “River Ridge High School Band Boosters” in the black mailbox by the band room door, Zelle (riverridgehsbandboosters@gmail.com), or Venmo (@rrhsbb).

Students and families who secure sponsorships for the band program are eligible to receive 50% of the sponsorship amount credited directly toward the student’s band fee balance. For example, a \$500 sponsorship would result in a \$250 credit applied to your fees.

Any band fee balances left unpaid or fundraising money not submitted at the deadline could affect the student’s eligibility to attend the end of year banquet, voluntary band trips, and participation in non-curricular events until the accounts are settled. The intention is not to

penalize or exclude students who have financial hardships, but rather to create a fair and equitable solution for the good of the program.

Students will never be denied participation in any part of the program due to financial difficulties.

However, communication is key to making sure a plan is worked out and the budget can be made accordingly.

Band Fees/Fair Share payments are non-refundable. The annual budget is based upon the needs of the band program being divided equally among the program's enrollment. Failure to participate in the band program will not relieve the student of his/her responsibility. Failure to maintain academic eligibility will not relieve the student of his/her responsibility.

With this being said, no student will be held out of participation if his or her family is unable to pay their assessed portion. We have numerous plans in place for families that request assistance. Please contact Mr. Scholz or the Band Boosters directly to resolve out these issues.

Fundraisers

There will be fundraisers all year. Students and parents are required to participate throughout the year. Proceeds from fundraisers go into the general operating fund of the band program and will allow us to meet the many financial obligations that are part of sustaining our thriving music program and keeping our program accessible to all students.

Here is a list of our main fundraisers:

SnapRaise

Parking at Football Games

Concessions

Sponsorships

Car Show

Month of Giving (Personal Fundraiser)

Raymond James (TBD...)

Student Leadership

Band Captain (Executive Board)- Gavin Covert

-Top of the chain of the command

-Oversees administrative leadership (librarians, operations team, social media)

-Ensure that all equipment is brought out for rehearsal. Handle equipment in the event that we are missing operations team.

-On field eyes and ears

- 15 minutes early, 15 minutes late
- Leadership inspections
- Bus captain
- All county, solo and ensemble
- Assist section leaders with planning team building and icebreaker activities

Drum Majors (Executive Board)- Brecklynn Bashant and Ava Pigeon

- Top of the chain of the command
- Oversees instructional leadership (section captains)
- Ensure that all equipment is brought out for rehearsal. Handle equipment in the event that we are missing operations team.
- Take attendance at rehearsals

- 15 minutes early, 15 minutes late
- Leadership inspections
- Bus captain
- All County, solo and ensemble
- Assist section leaders with planning team building and ice-breaker activities

Band Section Captains- Samantha Ticich, Tanner Osarczuk, Joseph Lyons, Marissa Garone, Amber Forcade

- 15 minutes early, 15 minutes late
- Facilitate mandatory weekly sectionals
- Oversee inspection for section members
- Offer individual help to section members when needed
- Plan and lead team building/ ice breaker activities for you respective sections -All County, solo and ensemble
- Create a section welcome gift

Colorguard Section Captain- Delana Pillars

- 15 minutes early, 15 minutes late
- Facilitate mandatory weekly sectionals
- Oversee inspection for section members
- Offer individual help to section members when needed
- Plan and lead team building/ ice breaker activities for you respective sections
- Keep the guard room in clean working order
- Create a section welcome gift for the first day of band camp

Librarian- Baxter Henry

- 15 minutes early, 15 minutes late
- Copy and organize all music and drill according to rehearsal schedules -Pass out music and drill during rehearsals
- All County, solo and ensemble

Operations Team- William Speer (Manager), Pj Drougas, Joseph Lyons, Marissa Garone, William Levine, Amber Forcade

-15 minutes early, 15 minutes late

-Choose a team of helpers (operations helpers will not be a leadership position)

-Ensure that all equipment is out before the start of rehearsal based on the materials list that is posted with the rehearsal schedule

-Set up podium

-Facilitate trailer loading

-All county, solo and ensemble

Social Media Team- Brady Smyth, Chelsea Haggerty

-15 minutes early, 15 minutes late

-Keep Royal Sound instagram and facebook page up to date, make tiktoks (approx. 2 insta/facebook posts per week, at least 2 tiktoks per month)

-Create graphics for events and performances to advertise the band program

-Create schedule for section instagram takeovers

-All county, solo and ensemble

Band Chain of Command

Principal (Ms.McPherson)

Assistant Principals (Ms. Donlon, Coach Baker, Mr. Bruno, Ms. Sumrall)

Band Director (Ms. Scholz)

Percussion and Colorguard Directors (John Chiarella, Madison Nelson)

Band Staff

Band Parent Volunteers (as appointed)

Drum Majors and Band Captain

Section Captains

Band Leadership

Private Instruction

Students are **highly encouraged** to study privately to help their musical performance. Here is a list of some local private instructors.

Dr. Mandy Swaim, Flute/Piccolo – music.mandym@gmail.com

Mrs. Megan Richardson, Flute – mdrichardson08@gmail.com

Mr. Jeff MacKechnie, Saxophones/Clarinet/Double Reeds – jmacke70@gmail.com

Mr. Joshua Hollenbeck, Saxophones/Clarinet – jhollenb@pasco.k12.fl.us

Mrs. Mariah Walukonis, Clarinet – mcmcdona@pasco.k12.fl.us

Steven Alvarez, Trumpet – steven20042010@hotmail.com

Mr. Benjamin Walukonis, French Horn – bwalukon@pasco.k12.fl.us

Ms. Terry Adams, Trombone, Baritone, Tuba – cadams@pasco.k12.fl.us

Jacob Barber, Percussion- jtbarber99@gmail.com

Chris Demas, Percussion- chrisdemas026@gmail.com

Bryce Landry, Percussion and Drumset- bmlandry18@gmail.com

2025-2026 Band Handbook Agreement

Parent/ Guardian: I understand the requirements and responsibilities for membership in the River Ridge High School Band Program. I have read and understand the policies concerning grading, behavior, and attendance. I recognize that my student is enrolled in a performance-based curriculum for academic credit and that suspension from rehearsals or performances as a disciplinary action may negatively impact their grade.

NAME OF PARENT: _____

SIGNATURE OF PARENT: _____

PREFERRED TELEPHONE: _____

STUDENT: I have read and agree to abide by the principles, ideals, procedures, and guidelines set further in this handbook, and I understand the consequences for non-compliance. I AM COMMITTED!

NAME OF STUDENT: _____

SIGNATURE OF STUDENT: _____

PLEASE SIGN AND RETURN NO LATER THAN AUGUST 18TH 2025

See back for parent volunteer opportunities

PARENT INVOLVEMENT

I have this expertise in this skill set and would be willing to assist the band in these ways (check ALL that apply)

- ☐ Uniform fitting
- ☐ Organizing or Alphabetizing
- ☐ Typing
- ☐ Spread-sheet expertise
- ☐ Database expertise
- ☐ Collecting sponsorships and donations
- ☐ Sewing (Flag work), Hemming
- ☐ Flag making
- ☐ Ticket Sales
- ☐ Welding, Carpentry, Handy work
- ☐ Organizing and assisting in fundraising
- ☐ Concessions Vending
- ☐ Painting
- ☐ Dry Cleaning, Uniform Washing
- ☐ Audio Electronics
- ☐ Equipment Truck Driving
- ☐ Medical Career (Nursing, Physician, EMT, etc.)
- ☐ Recruiting Chaperones
- ☐ Organizing Private Lessons
- ☐ Offering transportation
- ☐ Notarizing

I, _____, signify that I would be willing to assist the band where I have indicated, should there ever be a need to help in these ways!

I can be reached at this e-mail address:

I can be reached at this phone number:
